Beyond Data: AI for Human Connection

SYNC

Top 10 Trends:

Nonprofit Development & Fundraising

Beyond Data: AI for Human Connection SYNC

StratusLIVE

Agenda

1. The Funding Landscape
2. You're Not All the Same Org
3. The 10 Trends — With Context
4. Your Move: Action Framework
5. Q & A + Discussion

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What is your organization's primary fundraising model?

- Workplace / payroll giving campaigns
- Events & peer-to-peer fundraising
- Individual giving & annual fund
- Corporate & foundation grants
- Major gifts & planned giving
- A mix of several of the above

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The Funding Landscape

Where the money is coming from — and what the data actually says

Philanthropy Is Still Growing — But Not Evenly

$592.5B
Total U.S. charitable giving in 2024

+3.3%
Real growth after inflation

~80%
First-time donors who never give a second gift

~32%
Sector-wide donor retention rate

The headline looks strong. The retention reality doesn't.

✓ What's Working

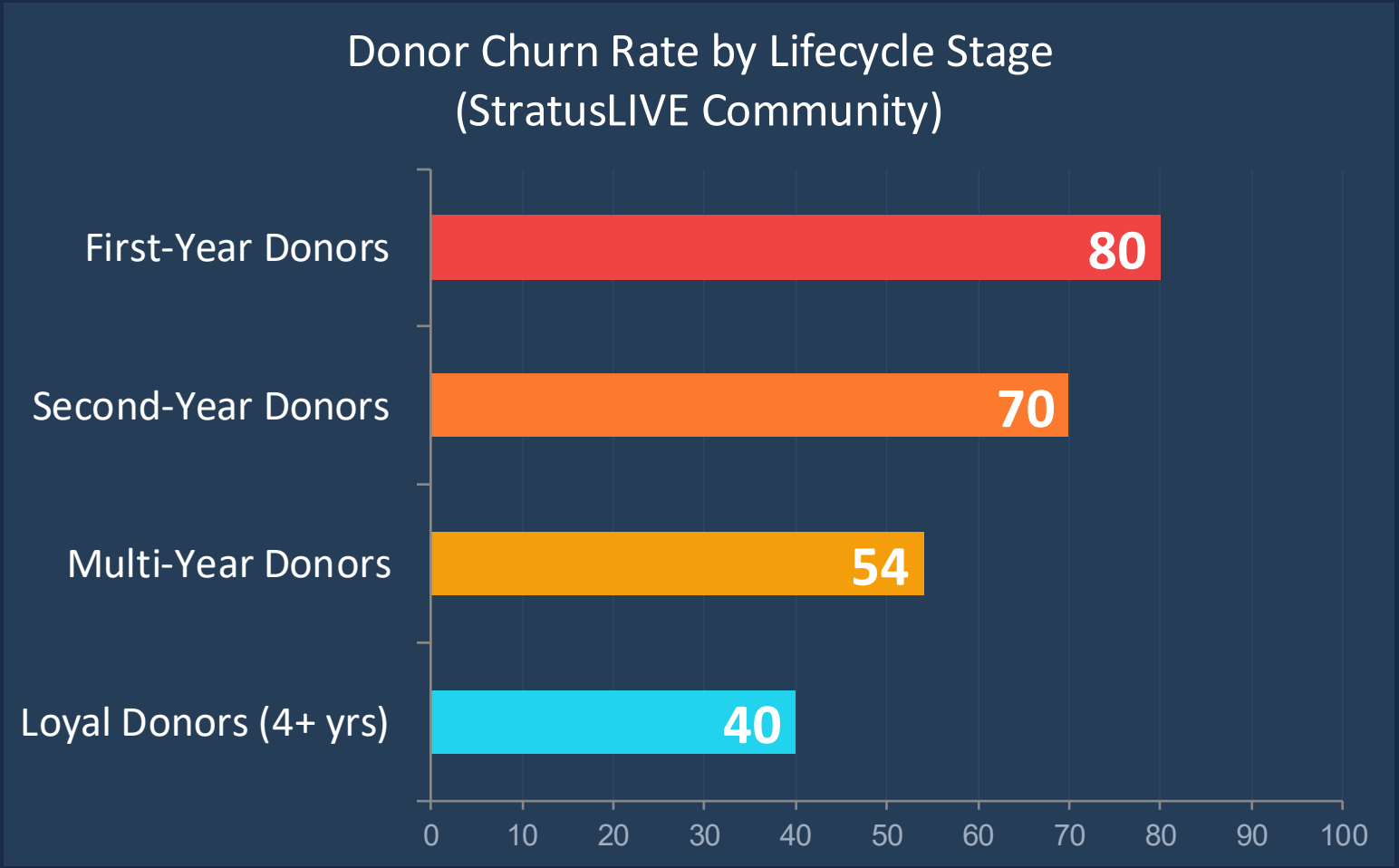
- Major gifts & high-capacity donors driving gains
- DAF and corporate channels expanding fast
- Average gift sizes increasing sector-wide
- Digital-first orgs significantly outperforming peers

✗ The Strategic Risk

- Active donor counts declining sector-wide
- Smaller donors disappearing from files
- Acquisition costs keep rising year over year
- Base donor erosion is a strategic risk, not a campaign risk

Sources: Giving USA 2025 · Fundraising Effectiveness Project 2025

Your Peers' Data — The Real Cost of Churn



11M
Constituent records across 30 CRM clients

87%
Of all records: no gift in 36+ months

$13.7M
Annual revenue lost to churn in SL community

$21.4M
Cost to acquire replacements — 3× what they gave

87% churn is not a fixed fact — it is a fixable problem.
A 10-pt lift in first-year retention = ~12,600 more donors & ~$800K in recurring revenue annually.

Source: StratusLIVE Community Data (30 CRM clients, 11M records, April 2026)

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You're Not All the Same Org

How you raise money changes what you should prioritize

How You Raise Money Changes What You Should Prioritize

United Way / Federated

Workplace campaigns · corporate giving · Tocqueville major gifts

TOP PRIORITIES: DAF adoption · Participation rate growth · Leadership pipeline

Faith-Based (Human Services)

Major gifts · values-driven individual giving · volunteer-donor overlap

TOP PRIORITIES: Impact-led stewardship · Volunteer to donor conversion · HNW donor DAFs

Youth Dev / Education

Corporate sponsorships · alumni community · events

TOP PRIORITIES: P2P & community models · Corporate DAFs · Alumni recurring

Cause/Cure / P2P

Signature walks · P2P fundraising · individual appeals

TOP PRIORITIES: Post-event recurring conversion · P2P optimization · Retention

Arts / Culture

Workplace giving · corporate sponsorship · memberships

TOP PRIORITIES: Digital upgrade · Recurring memberships · DAF & leadership gifts

Food / Human Services

Grants · corporate · events · growing individual base

TOP PRIORITIES: Digital infrastructure · First-gift retention · DAF registration

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The 10 Trends — With Context

What's happening sector-wide, and what it means for your specific org type

TREND 1

DONOR RETENTION IS THE CENTRAL PROBLEM

~80%
First-time donors who never give again

3×
More expensive to acquire vs. retain

~32%
Sector-wide retention rate

62%
Revenue from donors giving 2+ years

Discussion: What does your first-year donor onboarding actually look like? Automated — or manual?

United Way / Federated

Employer-level retention is critical. Lapsed corporate accounts and your Tocqueville pipeline are the analog. Are those touchpoints systematized, or dependent on one person's relationships?

Faith-Based

Donors give from conviction — generic stewardship won't hold them. Tie impact stories to real outcomes and treat your volunteer base as an upgrade pipeline.

Events / P2P

Walk participants who don't convert to direct donors churn almost completely. One automated post-event ask for a monthly sustainer can change that math permanently.

Food & Human Services

First-gift retention is your largest leverage point. A single automated thank-you + impact sequence can lift first-year retention by 5–10 points with no new headcount.

Top numbers: Fundraising Effectiveness Project 2025 · Bottom numbers: StratusLIVE Community Data 2026

TREND 2

RECURRING GIVING IS THE CLEAREST GROWTH LEVER

+5%

Monthly giving YoY growth

31%

Of all online revenue is now recurring

80–90%

Recurring donor retention vs. 43% one-time

$10.2M

Potential from 10% one-time-to-monthly conversion (SL community)

Discussion: Is monthly giving your default option — or an afterthought? Where does it appear in your donor flow?

United Way / Federated

Are you making it equally easy for leadership and Tocqueville-tier donors to give via DAF, auto-charge, or direct bill? Diversifying within the campaign structure is the play.

Youth Dev / Education

Higher ed has proven the alumni monthly giving model works. A $25/month alumni program for recent grads could significantly extend lifetime value from community and event donors.

Faith-Based

Skip the subscription framing — recurring giving is about sustained impact. Position monthly gifts as what makes consistent service delivery possible. And your clearest upgrade path is the $500 donor who also volunteers regularly. That's your next major gift conversation.

Cause/Cure / P2P

Post-walk conversion to a monthly sustainer is the highest-ROI move available. Build the ask directly into the thank-you sequence — not as an afterthought, but as the designed next step.

Sources: M+R Benchmarks 2025 · Blackbaud 2025 · StratusLIVE Community Data

TRENDS 3 & 4 · THE DIGITAL GAP & THE SIZE DIVIDE

TREND 3 — The Digital Gap

11%
Raise nothing digitally

20%
Raise ≥50% revenue online

$439
Ignite avg gift vs. $150–200 industry avg

The opportunity: Ignite donation pages perform 2–3× above industry averages. Digital-first orgs are gaining ground fast — the gap between adopters and laggards is widening every year.

TREND 4 — The Size Advantage Widens

+4.3%
Revenue growth, typical nonprofits

-6.4%
Revenue decline for small orgs in 2025

+4.7%
Growth in gifts of $1,000+ in 2025

The implication: Scale and sophisticated operations are amplifying already-strong organizations. The gap isn't closing. It's accelerating.

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AI is the great equalizer, and you don't need to be a large org to use it.

Predictive donor scoring, automated stewardship, personalized ask amounts, churn risk alerts — these used to require a team of data analysts. Today they're built into platforms like Ignite. The gap between large and small orgs isn't really about budget anymore. It's about whether you're activating the tools you already have.

Sources: Blackbaud 2025 · Nonprofit Tech for Good 2025 · StratusLIVE Community Data

TRENDS 5 & 6 · CONCENTRATION RISK & DAFS

TREND 5 — Year-End Concentration Risk

36% of all charitable giving concentrates in Q4

18% comes in December alone — massive concentration risk

Note for federated organizations: your fall campaign structure shifts this risk profile.
Your question: what drives reliable Q1–Q3 revenue?

TREND 6 — DAFs & Major Gifts Are Reshaping Revenue

$250B+
Undeployed assets sitting in DAFs nationally

+6%
DAF revenue growth in 2024

$1,500+
Avg DAF/Direct Bill gift vs. $492 payroll avg

+34%
Direct Bill/DAF growth in SL community (3yr)

Action: Is your org registered to receive DAF grants? For United Ways, your Tocqueville donors are prime DAF candidates.

Sources: National Philanthropic Trust 2024 · Blackbaud 2025 · StratusLIVE Community Data

TRENDS 7–10 · PEER-TO-PEER, TECHNOLOGY & THE AI OPPORTUNITY

7 P2P & Community Models

$1.17B

Top 30 P2P programs raised in 2025, 2.63M participants

P2P is a core acquisition strategy. Alumni events and walks already live here. The question is whether engagement feeds your CRM and long-term donor file.

8 Ad Spend & Connected TV

+84%

Connected TV nonprofit ad spend growth — video-first is the new standard

Primarily relevant at larger scale — but the principle applies everywhere: meet donors in their attention environment, not just your email list.

9 Influencer & Social Giving

~50%

Of nonprofits worked with social media influencers in 2024

For P2P and cause-based orgs: your walk participants are already recruiting their own networks — that's peer influence in action. The question is whether you're giving them content, tools, and a reason to keep talking about your mission between events, not just during registration season.

10 AI & Automation

NOW

AI-driven personalization is shifting from "nice to have" to table stakes

Predictive scoring, automated stewardship, and AI insights are built into Ignite and StratusLIVE 365 CRM. The question isn't whether to use AI — it's whether you're activating what you already have.

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Open Mentimeter

Which of these trends feels most urgent for your organization right now?

- Fixing our donor retention rate
- Reducing year-end concentration risk
- Building / growing our recurring giving program
- Expanding P2P / community fundraising
- Improving our digital fundraising capacity
- Growing workplace giving participation rate
- Activating DAFs & major gift pipeline
- Investing in AI, technology & data infrastructure

4

So What Do You Actually Do?

From insight to action — matched to your model and your biggest blocker

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Keep Mentimeter open

What's slowing you down from fixing your fundraising challenges?

1. Getting leadership to prioritize it
2. Our current systems can't execute this yet
3. Not enough staff or bandwidth
4. Not sure which problems we need to solve
5. We're already moving on it — here to go deeper

Where Should Your Org Focus? — Priority Matrix by Fundraising Model

Trend	United Way / Federated	Faith-Based	Youth / Ed	Health / P2P	Arts	Food / Human Svc
Donor Retention	HIGH	HIGH	HIGH	HIGH	HIGH	HIGH
Recurring Giving	MED	HIGH	MED	HIGH	MED	MED
Digital Fundraising	MED	MED	MED	HIGH	MED	HIGH
DAFs & Major Gifts	HIGH	HIGH	MED	MED	HIGH	HIGH
Year-End Concentration	LOW	MED	HIGH	HIGH	LOW	MED
P2P & Community	LOW	LOW	HIGH	HIGH	LOW	MED
AI & Automation	HIGH	HIGH	MED	MED	MED	MED

Starting point — not a prescription. Your mission, data, and current state should drive the final call.

If Your Blocker Is ___ — Your First Move Is ___

🏛️ **Leadership won't prioritize it**	**Your move:** 1-page CEO memo. Lead with opportunity. Show the churn cost, Then ask for one thing.
⚙️ **Our systems can't execute this**	**Your move:** Audit your top 3 capability gaps. Solve the most expensive gap first.
👥 **Not enough staff or bandwidth**	**Your move:** Automate stewardship for your loyal segment first. One automated sequence. Start there, then expand.
🗺️ **Not sure what applies to us**	**Your move:** Run your retention rate today. Below 43%, retention is your answer. Above 43%, look at recurring conversion.
🚀 **Already moving — here for depth**	**Your move:** Identify your pre-lapse segment. That's your most recoverable group right now. Build one targeted reactivation sequence, measure it, then upgrade your monthly giving ask.

Let's Talk.

- Which trend are you going back to work on first?
- What's the one thing that would most unblock you?
- Who else in your org needs to be in this conversation?

stratuslive.com · info@stratuslive.com